

Anchoring Cliques in Clique Wrappers

A supplement to “A Least Squares Framework for the Maximum Weight Clique Problem”

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Abstract

The non-edge entries of a wrapping matrix are free parameters of the clique wrapper. *Anchoring* spends them on a chosen maximal clique Q so that Q satisfies the hypothesis of [CW, Theorem 2]; its indicator then becomes a stationary point of the relaxed least squares program and lies on the curve that the secular equation traces. We collect what was established about anchoring, theoretically and in experiments with QUALEX-MS. For a single clique we give the construction, show that the indicator is then a point of the secular curve, and compute the curvature of the wrapper towards every other clique, which explains why anchoring acts as a local exchange around Q ; the experiments confirm this and show that anchoring pays off as a second pass on a good clique and not otherwise. For several cliques the levels at which they can be anchored are forced: two anchored cliques Q_a, Q_b satisfy $\mu_a W(Q_b \setminus Q_a) = \mu_b W(Q_a \setminus Q_b)$, so cliques of equal weight share one level, and a shared level creates exactly the degenerate case (multiple eigenvalues with vanishing linear form) that the secular equation cannot see. We characterize when two cliques can be anchored together. Over all wrappers the best value of the relaxed program is $1/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$, the reciprocal of the Lovász number, and the standard wrapper gives Hoffman’s bound on regular graphs; a clique indicator can be a global minimizer of the relaxed program only if $\omega(G, w) = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$, in which case every Lovász-optimal wrapper anchors all maximum cliques at the top of the spectrum, in the hard case of the trust region problem. Odd holes and odd antiholes admit no nontrivial anchoring of all their maximum cliques, which with the strong perfect graph theorem characterizes perfect graphs. Computations with a maximal clique enumerator and with CSDP illustrate the results on the DIMACS graphs and on random graphs.

Contents

1	Introduction	2
2	Setting	3
2.1	Wrapping matrices	3
2.2	The relaxed program and its stationary points	4
2.3	The gauge	5
3	Anchoring one clique	6

4	Anchoring one clique in QUALEX-MS: experiments	7
4.1	Protocol and provenance	7
4.2	The construction and the spectrum	8
4.3	Cold, warm and iterated anchoring	8
4.4	Blending in one step of $\lambda_{\max}$ minimization	9
5	Anchoring several cliques	10
6	Anchoring every maximum clique	12
6.1	The best relaxation is the Lovász number	12
6.2	Global anchoring	13
6.3	Colourings, holes and perfect graphs	14
7	Computations	16
7.1	Tools	16
7.2	Anchoring all maximum cliques of DIMACS graphs	16
7.3	Random graphs	18
7.4	The Lovász number of the 14 undecided graphs	18
7.5	Relaxed bounds of the standard and the optimal wrapper	18
8	Conclusions and open questions	18

1 Introduction

This note supplements [CW], whose notation it follows, and refers to its statements as [CW, Theorem 2] and so on. The same notation is used in QUALEX-MS [Bu06], whose trust region stage finds the stationary points of [CW, Section 5]; Remark 2.4 gives the dictionary.

[CW, Theorem 2] says that a maximal clique Q is recognized through a stationary point of the relaxed least squares program [CW, (7)] whenever every vertex outside Q is attached to Q with the same weight, measured through the wrapping matrix H [CW, (6)]:

$$\sum_{j \in Q} h_{ij} z_j = C z_i \quad \forall i \in V \setminus Q. \quad (1)$$

For the standard wrapping matrix this is a strong combinatorial condition ([CW, Corollary 1]), and it rarely holds. But the entries of H on non-adjacent pairs are free, and (1) is linear in them. *Anchoring Q* means choosing them so that (1) holds. (The solver’s sources and diagnostics call (1) “Theorem 8”.)

The questions studied were:

1. What does anchoring one clique do to the stationary points, and is it useful in QUALEX-MS? (Sections 3 and 4.)
2. Can several cliques, in particular all maximum weight cliques, be anchored in one wrapper, and what does such a wrapper look like? (Sections 5 and 6.) For perfect graphs one expects the Lovász-optimal wrapper to anchor all maximum cliques at $\mu = \lambda_{\max}$; for general graphs the conditions look overdetermined.

3. How do these statements look on actual graphs? (Section 7.)

The main findings, in the order of the text:

- Anchoring one maximal clique is always possible, lowering entries only (Proposition 3.4); it makes the indicator of Q the point of the secular curve at the multiplier $\mu_Q = W(Q) - C$ (Lemma 3.3). The curvature of the wrapper along the direction from x^Q to any other clique Q' exceeds μ_Q by exactly $\mu_Q(W(Q') - W(Q))/W(Q \triangle Q')$, whatever the free entries are (Proposition 3.5).
- In QUALEX-MS, anchoring the clique found by a standard pass and solving again never lost on 366 test graphs and improved 55 of 120 weighted random graphs; anchoring the greedy clique lost far more often than it won (Section 4).
- Two cliques anchored in one wrapper satisfy the *level identity* $\mu_a W(Q_b \setminus Q_a) = \mu_b W(Q_a \setminus Q_b)$ (Theorem 5.1). Cliques of equal weight therefore share a level, and a shared level forces an eigenvalue of $\hat{H}$ whose eigenspace contains the differences of their indicators and carries no linear form (Theorem 5.3): the degenerate case excluded in [CW, Section 5]. Theorem 5.4 characterizes when two cliques can be anchored together; two maximum weight cliques always can (Corollary 5.5), though some non-edges may have to be made invisible (Proposition 5.6).
- $\max_H \min\{x^T x : x \in \mathcal{W}^H\} = 1/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ (Theorem 6.1); for regular graphs the standard wrapper attains Hoffman's ratio bound instead (Corollary 6.2). A clique indicator is a global minimizer of the relaxed program for some wrapper iff $W(Q) = \omega(G, w) = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ (Theorem 6.3); then every Lovász-optimal wrapper anchors every maximum clique at $\mu = \lambda_{\max}(\hat{H})$, the hard case of the trust region problem (Corollary 6.4).
- Anchoring all maximum cliques of an odd hole or an odd antihole forces the level to 0 (Theorem 6.6), while graphs with $\chi = \omega$ have an explicit Lovász-optimal wrapper anchoring them all (Proposition 6.5). Hence a graph is perfect iff every induced subgraph admits an anchoring of all its maximum cliques at a nonzero level (Theorem 6.7).
- Of the 31 DIMACS graphs with $n \leq 1100$ and between 2 and 20000 maximum cliques, 11 do not admit anchoring all of them at a nonzero level; of the remaining 20, 14 have $\vartheta = \omega$ and 6 have $\vartheta > \omega$ (Section 7).

2 Setting

2.1 Wrapping matrices

Let $G(V, E)$, $V = \{1, \dots, n\}$, have positive vertex weights w , let $z_i = \sqrt{w_i}$ and $W(S) = \sum_{i \in S} w_i$, and let $N(i)$ be the neighborhood of i . For $S \subseteq V$ we write $\mathbf{1}_S$ for its characteristic vector, z_S for the vector with $(z_S)_i = z_i$ on S and 0 elsewhere, and $x^S = z_S/W(S)$ for its indicator [CW, Definition 1].

Definition 2.1. $\mathcal{H}(G, w)$ is the set of real symmetric $n \times n$ matrices H with $h_{ij} = z_i z_j$ whenever $i = j$ or $(i, j) \in E$. For $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$ and a non-adjacent pair $i \neq j$ we write

$$h_{ij} = z_i z_j (1 - \tau_{ij}),$$

and call $\tau_{ij} = \tau_{ji}$ the *defect* of the non-edge. The standard wrapping matrix H_0 of [CW] has $\tau \equiv 1$. The wrapping matrices of [CW], which need $h_{ij} < z_i z_j$ off E , are the H with all defects positive; we call them *proper*.

Every $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$ defines the surface $\mathcal{W}^H = \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n : x^T H x = 1, z^T x = 1\}$. The computation in the proof of [CW, Proposition 2] involves only entries of H inside the clique, so *every clique indicator lies on $\mathcal{W}^H$ for every $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$* . Nonnegative defects are exactly what [CW, Proposition 1] needs.

The weighted Lovász number of the complement of G is

$$\vartheta(\bar{G}, w) = \min_{H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)} \lambda_{\max}(H) \quad (2)$$

$$= \max\{\langle zz^T, X \rangle : X \succeq 0, \operatorname{tr} X = 1, X_{ij} = 0 \text{ for } i \neq j, (i, j) \notin E\}, \quad (3)$$

where both optima are attained [Lo79, GLS88, Kn94]. We call a matrix attaining (2) a *Lovász-optimal* wrapping matrix and a matrix attaining (3) a *Lovász optimum*. Since the two programs have equal values, every Lovász-optimal H and every Lovász optimum X satisfy the complementarity condition

$$(\vartheta(\bar{G}, w) I - H) X = 0, \quad (4)$$

because $\operatorname{tr}((\vartheta(\bar{G}, w) I - H) X) = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w) - \langle zz^T, X \rangle = 0$ (H and zz^T agree on the support of X) and both factors are positive semidefinite.

Lemma 2.2. *For every $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$ and every clique Q , $z_Q^T H z_Q = W(Q)^2$. Hence $\lambda_{\max}(H) \geq W(Q)$ and $\omega(G, w) \leq \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$; and $X_Q = z_Q z_Q^T / W(Q)$ is feasible in (3) with value $W(Q)$.*

Proof. $z_Q^T H z_Q = \sum_{i,j \in Q} z_i z_j h_{ij} = \sum_{i,j \in Q} w_i w_j = W(Q)^2$ and $\|z_Q\|^2 = W(Q)$, so the Rayleigh quotient of z_Q is $W(Q)$. X_Q is positive semidefinite with trace 1 and is supported on $Q \times Q$, where all pairs are adjacent; its value is $(z^T z_Q)^2 / W(Q) = W(Q)$. $\square$

2.2 The relaxed program and its stationary points

For $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$ let

$$v(H) = \min\{x^T x : x \in \mathcal{W}^H\}, \quad (5)$$

the relaxed program [CW, (7)]. It is feasible (clique indicators) and its objective is coercive, so the minimum is attained, and $v(H) \leq 1/\omega(G, w)$.

As in [CW, Section 5] let $x^0 = z/W(V)$, $P = I - zz^T/W(V)$, $\hat{H} = PHP$, $\hat{b} = PHx^0$ and $s = 1 - (x^0)^T H x^0$. Writing $x = x^0 + \hat{x}$ with $\hat{x} \perp z$,

$$x^T x = \|x^0\|^2 + \|\hat{x}\|^2, \quad x^T H x = 1 \iff q(\hat{x}) := \hat{x}^T \hat{H} \hat{x} + 2\hat{b}^T \hat{x} = s.$$

In terms of the defects, $s = W(V)^{-2} \sum w_i w_j \tau_{ij}$, the sum running over ordered non-adjacent pairs $i \neq j$, so $s > 0$ for proper wrapping matrices. Throughout, eigenvalues of $\hat{H}$ are those of its restriction to $z^\perp$ (on z itself $\hat{H}$ vanishes).

With the multiplier convention of [CW] (the multiplier of the quadratic constraint written as $-1/\mu$), a point $x = x^0 + \hat{x} \in \mathcal{W}^H$ is *stationary with multiplier $\mu \neq 0$* if

$$(\mu I - \hat{H}) \hat{x} = \hat{b} \quad \text{on } z^\perp. \quad (6)$$

In the eigenvector basis $\hat{H} = U \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_i) U^T$, $c = U^T \hat{b}$, $y = U^T \hat{x}$, (6) reads $(\mu - \lambda_i) y_i = c_i$. For μ not an eigenvalue, $x(\mu) = x^0 + (\mu I - \hat{H})^{-1} \hat{b}$ is the *secular curve*, and $x(\mu) \in \mathcal{W}^H$ iff μ solves the secular equation [CW, (19)].

Lemma 2.3. *Let $x = x^0 + \hat{x} \in \mathcal{W}^H$.*

(a) *If x is stationary with a multiplier $\mu > 0$ such that $\mu \geq \lambda_{\max}(\hat{H})$, then x is a global minimizer of (5).*

(b) *If $s > 0$, $\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H}) > 0$ and x is a global minimizer of (5), then x is stationary with a multiplier $\mu \geq \lambda_{\max}(\hat{H})$.*

Proof. (a) On $z^\perp$ the function $L(y) = \|y\|^2 - \mu^{-1}(q(y) - s)$ has the Hessian $2(I - \hat{H}/\mu) \succeq 0$, so it is convex, and $\nabla L(\hat{x}) = 0$ by (6). Hence for every feasible y (i.e. $q(y) = s$) $\|y\|^2 = L(y) \geq L(\hat{x}) = \|\hat{x}\|^2$.

(b) Let $r = \|\hat{x}\|$. If some $y \in z^\perp$ with $\|y\| < r$ had $q(y) \geq s$, then, since $q(0) = 0 < s$, $q(ty) = s$ for some $t \in (0, 1]$, a feasible point of norm $t\|y\| < r$. So $q < s$ on the open ball of radius r and, by continuity, $\hat{x}$ maximizes q over the closed ball. By the characterization of trust region solutions [MS83] applied to $-q$ there is $\mu \geq 0$ with $(\mu I - \hat{H})\hat{x} = \hat{b}$ and $\mu I - \hat{H} \succeq 0$ on $z^\perp$; thus $\mu \geq \lambda_{\max}(\hat{H}) > 0$. $\square$

Remark 2.4 (QUALEX-MS). The trust region program of [Bu06] (cf. [CW, Theorem 3]) maximizes $x^T A x$, $A = H - w_{\min} I$, over $z^T x = 1$, $\|x\| = r$. On such a sphere $x^T x$ is constant, so its stationary points are those of q on $\|x\| = \sqrt{r^2 - \|x^0\|^2}$; they satisfy (6) with the same $\hat{x}$. The solver works with $\hat{A} = P A P = \hat{H} - w_{\min} P$ and the multiplier $\mu^* = \mu - w_{\min}$: the same eigenvectors and linear form, all eigenvalues and multipliers shifted by $w_{\min}$. By Lemma 2.3, when $s > 0$ and $\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H}) > 0$ the global minimizers of (5) are the stationary points with $\mu \geq \lambda_{\max}(\hat{H})$, which are the global maximizers of the trust region objective on their own sphere [MS83]; in the solver's terms, $\mu^* \geq \lambda_{\max}(\hat{A})$. Counts of “eigenvalues above μ^* ” reported by the solver are counts of eigenvalues of $\hat{H}$ above μ .

2.3 The gauge

Lemma 2.5. *For $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$ and $t \neq -1$ let $H_t = (1+t)H - tzz^T$. Then $H_t \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$ with defects $(1+t)\tau$, $\mathcal{W}^{H_t} = \mathcal{W}^H$ and $v(H_t) = v(H)$; moreover $\hat{H}_t = (1+t)\hat{H}$, $\hat{b}_t = (1+t)\hat{b}$, $s_t = (1+t)s$, and a point is stationary for H with multiplier μ iff it is stationary for H_t with multiplier $(1+t)\mu$.*

Proof. On E and the diagonal the entries of H_t are $(1+t)z_i z_j - t z_i z_j = z_i z_j$, and on a non-edge $(1+t)z_i z_j(1 - \tau_{ij}) - t z_i z_j = z_i z_j(1 - (1+t)\tau_{ij})$. For $z^T x = 1$, $x^T H_t x = (1+t)x^T H x - t$, which equals 1 iff $x^T H x = 1$. Since $Pz = 0$, $\hat{H}_t = (1+t)\hat{H}$ and $\hat{b}_t = (1+t)PHx^0 - tPz(z^T x^0) = (1+t)\hat{b}$, and $s_t = 1 - (1+t)(x^0)^T H x^0 + t = (1+t)s$. Multiplying (6) by $1+t$ gives the last claim. $\square$

So the wrapper surface depends only on the defects up to a common factor, and the multipliers are defined up to the same factor. In particular the uniform perturbation of the standard wrapper, $h_{ij} = -tz_i z_j$ on every non-edge, is $(H_0)_t$ and changes nothing. For $1+t > 0$ the position of a multiplier within the spectrum of $\hat{H}$ and the ratio

$$\rho(H) = \frac{\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H}) - \lambda_{\min}(\hat{H})}{\|\hat{b}\|}$$

are invariant; absolute spectral widths are not.

3 Anchoring one clique

Definition 3.1. A maximal clique Q is *anchored at level μ* in $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$ if (1) holds with $C = W(Q) - \mu$.

Lemma 3.2. *The following are equivalent:*

- (a) Q is anchored at level μ in H ;
- (b) $\sum_{j \in Q \setminus N(i)} w_j \tau_{ij} = \mu$ for every $i \in V \setminus Q$;
- (c) $H z_Q = (W(Q) - \mu) z + \mu z_Q$.

Proof. For $i \notin Q$, $\sum_{j \in Q} h_{ij} z_j = z_i \sum_{j \in Q \cap N(i)} w_j + z_i \sum_{j \in Q \setminus N(i)} w_j (1 - \tau_{ij}) = z_i (W(Q) - \sum_{j \in Q \setminus N(i)} w_j \tau_{ij})$, which gives (a) $\iff$ (b). For $i \in Q$, $(H z_Q)_i = z_i W(Q)$, which is the i -th entry of the right-hand side of (c) for every μ ; for $i \notin Q$ the i -th entry of (c) is (1). $\square$

For the standard wrapper the sum in (b) is $W(Q \setminus N(i))$, the weight of the non-neighbours of i in Q , so Q is anchored in H_0 iff that weight is the same for all outside vertices, which is [CW, Corollary 1]. Note that a clique that is not maximal can only be “anchored” at level 0: a vertex adjacent to all of Q has an empty sum in (b).

Lemma 3.3. *Let Q be a maximal clique and $\mu \neq 0$. Then Q is anchored at level μ in H iff x^Q is a stationary point of (5) with multiplier μ . In that case $\hat{x}^Q = x^Q - x^0$ satisfies $(\mu I - \hat{H}) \hat{x}^Q = \hat{b}$, and if μ is not an eigenvalue of $\hat{H}$ then $x^Q = x(\mu)$ is the point of the secular curve at μ and μ is a root of the secular equation.*

Proof. Since $z^T x^Q = 1$, $P x^Q = x^Q - x^0 = \hat{x}^Q$, and $P H x^Q = P H (x^0 + \hat{x}^Q) = \hat{b} + \hat{H} \hat{x}^Q$. If Q is anchored, Lemma 3.2(c) gives $H x^Q = \frac{W(Q) - \mu}{W(Q)} z + \mu x^Q$, so $P H x^Q = \mu \hat{x}^Q$, which is (6). Conversely, (6) says $P(H x^Q - \mu x^Q) = 0$, i.e. $H z_Q = \mu z_Q + \kappa z$ for some κ ; comparing an entry in Q gives $\kappa = W(Q) - \mu$, which is Lemma 3.2(c). $\square$

So anchoring is exactly what makes the secular equation of [CW] find Q : the curve $x(\mu)$ passes through x^Q at $\mu = \mu_Q$. [CW, Theorem 2] is the direction “anchored $\Rightarrow$ stationary”; for proper wrappers $\mu_Q > 0$ by Lemma 3.2(b).

Proposition 3.4 (the construction). *Let Q be a maximal clique and $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$. For $i \notin Q$ let $C_i = z_i^{-1} \sum_{j \in Q} h_{ij} z_j$ and $m_i = W(Q \setminus N(i)) > 0$. For any $C \leq \min_{i \notin Q} C_i$, the matrix H' obtained by*

$$h'_{ij} = h_{ij} + \frac{C - C_i}{m_i} z_i z_j \quad (i \notin Q, j \in Q \setminus N(i)),$$

all other entries unchanged, lies in $\mathcal{H}(G, w)$, satisfies $H' \leq H$ entrywise, and anchors Q at level $W(Q) - C$. If H is proper so is H' .

Proof. A non-edge between $i \notin Q$ and $j \in Q$ enters condition (1) of i only, so the conditions can be met one outside vertex at a time; the correction raises C_i by $\frac{C - C_i}{m_i} \sum_{j \in Q \setminus N(i)} w_j = C - C_i$. The corrections are nonpositive, which lowers entries and raises defects. $\square$

QUALEX-MS implements this as `anchor_wrapper()` with $C = \min_i C_i$, optionally damping all corrections by a factor $\theta \in (0, 1]$. For a single clique every level can be reached; $C \leq \min_i C_i$ is what keeps the corrections nonpositive.

Proposition 3.5 (curvature towards other cliques). *Let Q be anchored at level μ in H , let $Q' \neq Q$ be any clique and $u = x^{Q'} - x^Q$. Then $u \perp z$ and*

$$\frac{u^T \hat{H} u}{u^T u} = \mu \left(1 + \frac{W(Q') - W(Q)}{W(Q \triangle Q')} \right).$$

Proof. Write $a = W(Q')$, $b = W(Q)$, $c = W(Q \cap Q')$. Since $z^T u = 0$, $u^T \hat{H} u = u^T H u$. By Lemma 2.2, $z_{Q'}^T H z_{Q'} = a^2$ and $z_Q^T H z_Q = b^2$; by Lemma 3.2(c), $z_{Q'}^T H z_Q = (b - \mu) z_{Q'}^T z + \mu z_Q^T z_Q = (b - \mu)a + \mu c$. Hence

$$u^T H u = \frac{a^2}{a^2} + \frac{b^2}{b^2} - \frac{2((b - \mu)a + \mu c)}{ab} = \frac{2\mu(a - c)}{ab}, \quad u^T u = \frac{1}{a} + \frac{1}{b} - \frac{2c}{ab} = \frac{a + b - 2c}{ab},$$

and $a + b - 2c = W(Q \triangle Q')$, so the quotient is $2\mu(a - c)/(a + b - 2c) = \mu(1 + (a - b)/(a + b - 2c))$. $\square$

Corollary 3.6. *Let Q be anchored at a level $\mu > 0$.*

- (a) *If some clique Q' is heavier than Q , then $\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H}) > \mu$: the anchored indicator is not a maximizer of the trust region program on its sphere, and the excess curvature towards Q' is the gain $W(Q') - W(Q)$ per unit of exchanged weight $W(Q \triangle Q')$, times μ .*
- (b) *Towards a clique of the same weight the curvature equals μ ; towards a lighter one it is smaller.*

Part (a) is quantitative, not merely the observation that $x^{Q'}$ is a feasible point of smaller norm: the directions of positive excess curvature point to heavier cliques, most strongly to those that differ from Q by a small exchange with a gain. This is the local exchange behaviour measured in Section 4.

4 Anchoring one clique in QUALEX-MS: experiments

4.1 Protocol and provenance

A QUALEX-MS *pass* builds a wrapping matrix, runs the trust region stage and refines the stationary points into cliques. The variants (named as in `bench/variants`) were:

head the standard pass with H_0 ;

anc (*cold*) one pass with H_0 anchored on the clique of the greedy MIN heuristic; **anc05** the same with $\theta = 0.5$; **ancs** with the corrections dealt out to randomly permuted outside vertices, so that (1) fails (a control); **ancp** re-anchored on each improvement, at most 4 anchored passes;

ancw (*warm*) the standard pass, then one pass anchored on its final clique; **ancws** its shuffled control; **ancwp** re-anchored on each improvement, at most 4 anchored passes;

icel as **ancw**, then one line-searched step of $\lambda_{\max}(H)$ minimization along the gradient $2u_i u_j$ (u the top eigenvector) on all non-edges, entries clipped at $h_{ij} \leq 0$, and re-anchoring (“fire and ice”); **icels** with the step’s entries shuffled over the non-edges; **ices** a step on $\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H})$ that only moves each outside vertex’s correction among its non-neighbours in Q , so that (1) stays exact;

lz the standard pass replaced by a pass on the $\lambda_{\max}$ -stepped standard wrapper; **lzw** that wrapper as a second pass after the standard one; **lzws** its shuffled control.

The test sets were the 70 DIMACS graphs outside the ten largest; a set of 56 weighted graphs; uniform random graphs $G(n, p)$ with $n \in \{200, 300, 500, 1000\}$, $p \in \{0.25, 0.5, 0.7, 0.8, 0.9, 0.95\}$, five of each, unweighted (**ru**) and with integer weights uniform on $\{1..10\}$ (**rw**), for 70 of the weighted and 50 of the unweighted of which cliquer [NÖ03] proved the optimum; and for the largest runs the ten largest DIMACS graphs and 24 random graphs with $n = 2000$.

Results quoted from the experiments of 12–13 September 2026 were measured before the benchmark tooling was put under version control; their logs, and the generator of the 56-graph weighted set, were lost when the machine’s `/tmp` was wiped. Tables 1 and 2 are reproducible: `bench/compare.py` computes them from the results committed to the QUALEX-MS repository (directory `bench/runs`, solver built from commit 6cebb51), and they reproduce the corresponding earlier figures exactly.

4.2 The construction and the spectrum

The construction is exact: on every anchored run the stationary point at μ_Q returned the indicator to 10^{-15} . The anchored indicator was never the maximizer on its sphere: between 8 and 276 eigenvalues of $\hat{H}$ lay above μ_Q (median 30 of 399 on DIMACS). Taking C below $\min_i C_i$ does not change this: each unit taken off C raises μ_Q by one but $\lambda_{\max}$ by 1.2 to 2.6, and the count above μ_Q levels off at up to $|Q|$ (the correction is supported on the $Q \times (V \setminus Q)$ block, so it has at most $|Q|$ positive eigenvalues). By Theorem 6.3 below, no choice could have made the indicator a global maximizer on these graphs unless $\vartheta = \omega$.

The corrections are large (smallest $t_i = (C - C_i)/m_i$: median -7 on DIMACS, -10 on weighted graphs, down to -132), and forced: a vertex missing a single vertex of Q must put its whole correction on one entry. One anchoring widens the absolute spectrum of $\hat{H}$ (spectral radius $\times 1.3$ to 2.1 on unweighted graphs, $\times 1.9$ to 3.6 on weighted random ones, 9 graphs), but it inflates $\hat{b}$ as well, and the gauge-invariant ratio $\rho(H)$ decreased on 5 of the 9 graphs (`brock200_1` 57 to 37, `g500_50_0` 88 to 40) and increased on 3 (`p_hat300-3` 23 to 40). Iterated anchoring does not compound: each pass rebuilds the standard wrapper and anchors once, and $\lambda_{\max}$ even fell as the anchor improved (`g2000_95_0` weighted: 127 standard, then 407, 266, 266, 261).

4.3 Cold, warm and iterated anchoring

Cold anchoring loses: DIMACS 2 better and 9 worse (`gen400_p0.9_65` 65 $\rightarrow$ 52), weighted random graphs 15 better and 67 worse. Neither $\theta = 0.5$, nor a shuffled anchor (11/76), nor iterating (31/50) rescued it. By Corollary 3.6, anchoring makes the neighbourhood of Q attractive; around a poor clique that is a bad place.

Warm anchoring never lost on 366 graphs. It improved 3 DIMACS graphs (`keller5` 26 $\rightarrow$ 27, `gen400_p0.9_55` 53 $\rightarrow$ 55, `MANN_a45` 342 $\rightarrow$ 343), 8 of the weighted-56, 15 of 120 unweighted and 55 of 120 weighted random graphs, at 1.5 to 1.9 times the time of one pass. A second pass on a randomly perturbed wrapper of comparable cost improved 2, 0, 2 and 21 of the same.

Iterating it (`ancwp`) keeps climbing on dense weighted graphs: 35 of the 120 weighted random graphs improved beyond the first anchored pass (total weight $+179$, seven still improving at the cap of four passes), 3 of the weighted-56 (`w_nrm_200_90_1`: 263 $\rightarrow$ 267 $\rightarrow$ 268 $\rightarrow$ 270 $\rightarrow$ 272, the optimum), 2 unweighted random graphs and no DIMACS graph; 38 of the 70 proven weighted

optima were reached. On the largest graphs iterated warm anchoring improved `keller6` $53 \rightarrow 55$ and `MANN_a81` $1096 \rightarrow 1098$, 3 of 12 unweighted $n = 2000$ graphs (`g2000_50_1` $15 \rightarrow 16$) and 8 of 12 weighted ones, with the largest gains seen (`g2000_95_0` $891 \rightarrow 932$, `g2000_90_0` $530 \rightarrow 555$), at 2 to 4 times the time.

The gains are local: a median of 2 vertices dropped and 3 added, 95–97% of the anchor kept (91% after iterating), against about 59% for the gains of a random wrapper. Whether meeting (1) exactly matters depends on density: on weighted random graphs with $p \leq 0.7$ the shuffled control did as well (11 improved against 7; 37 proven optima each), but for $p \in \{0.9, 0.95\}$ only the exact anchor worked (38 against 6), and likewise on dense unweighted graphs (12 against 1).

4.4 Blending in one step of $\lambda_{\max}$ minimization

Minimizing $\lambda_{\max}(H)$ over $\mathcal{H}(G, w)$ is the Lovász program (2); its optima are known to be highly degenerate, and Sections 5–6 explain why. One step of it was tried instead of the full minimization. The top eigenvector u of H was within about a percent of $z/\|z\|$, so the gradient $2u_i u_j$ has cosine 0.98 to 1.00 with the gauge direction $z_i z_j$ of Lemma 2.5, which changes nothing. The remainder drives $\hat{b}$ towards 0: by definition $\hat{b} = PHz/W(V)$ vanishes iff z is an eigenvector of H . The ratio $\rho(H)$ grew by a median factor of 1.23 to 1.65 per suite, where the shuffled control stayed at 1.00.

Against one warm anchored pass the step (`icel`) raised the proven weighted optima from 37 to 41 of 70, all four gains at $p \leq 0.5$ (5 better and 0 worse there, against 0 and 1 for `icels`), and the unweighted ones from 43 to 44 of 50; on dense graphs it was 7 better and 9 worse, no different from its control, and on DIMACS it gave back `MANN_a45` $343 \rightarrow 342$. The projected variant (`ices`) changed little (7 better, 5 worse on weighted random graphs). Without anchoring (`lz`, `lzw`) the step is mostly the effect of any large change of wrapper (Table 2). The step also raised the number of eigenvalues above μ_Q at the anchored point on 93 of the 120 weighted random graphs and lowered it on none (median 29.5 to 43): the benefit of `icel` over `ancw` is not a more stable anchor.

variant	proven optima (of 70)	vs head better/worse	$p \leq 0.5$	$p = 0.7$	$p \geq 0.8$
head	33	–	–	–	–
ancw	37	55/0	3/0	4/0	48/0
icel	41	59/0	7/0	4/0	48/0
lz	35	33/36	6/6	4/9	23/21
lzw	40	34/0	6/0	5/0	23/0
lzws	35	28/0	3/0	3/0	22/0
icel vs ancw		12/9	5/0	0/0	7/9
lzw vs lzws		20/18	5/1	3/3	12/14

Table 1: Weighted random graphs (120, of which 70 with proven optima). Time relative to head: `ancw` 1.88, `icel` 2.20, `lz` 1.34, `lzw` 1.98, `lzws` 1.76.

variant	DIMACS (70)	unweighted random (120)	weighted random (120)
lz	2/0	10/3	33/36
lzw	1/0	11/0	34/0
lzws	3/0	7/0	28/0

Table 2: One $\lambda_{\max}$ step without anchoring, better/worse against head. The DIMACS changes were DSJC1000.5 14 $\rightarrow$ 15 (lz, lzw), gen400_p0.9_55 53 $\rightarrow$ 54 (lz) and $\rightarrow$ 55 (lzws), keller5 26 $\rightarrow$ 27 and MANN_a45 342 $\rightarrow$ 343 (lzws). On the unweighted random graphs all three reach 43 of the 50 proven optima (head 42). For comparison, as second passes: a random wrapper 2/2/21, warm anchoring 3/15/55.

5 Anchoring several cliques

We say that H anchors the maximal cliques $Q_1, \dots, Q_k$ at levels $\mu_1, \dots, \mu_k$ if it anchors each Q_a at μ_a . By Lemma 3.2 this is a system of linear equations in the defects, one for each pair (Q_a, i) with $i \notin Q_a$:

$$\sum_{j \in Q_a \setminus N(i)} w_j \tau_{ij} = \mu_a. \quad (7)$$

A non-edge $\{i, j\}$ can now occur in several equations, and the system can be inconsistent. For $Q_a \neq Q_b$ we write $D_a = Q_a \setminus Q_b$, $D_b = Q_b \setminus Q_a$ and $K = Q_a \cap Q_b$; for maximal cliques D_a and D_b are nonempty.

Theorem 5.1 (level identity). *If H anchors two distinct maximal cliques Q_a, Q_b at levels μ_a, μ_b , then*

$$\mu_a W(Q_b \setminus Q_a) = \mu_b W(Q_a \setminus Q_b).$$

Proof. A vertex $i \in D_b$ lies outside Q_a and is adjacent to all of K , so its non-neighbours in Q_a lie in D_a and (7) reads $\sum_{j \in D_a \setminus N(i)} w_j \tau_{ij} = \mu_a$. Multiplying by w_i and summing over $i \in D_b$ gives $\sum w_i w_j \tau_{ij} = \mu_a W(D_b)$, the sum running over the non-edges between D_a and D_b . The same computation from the side of Q_b gives the same sum equal to $\mu_b W(D_a)$. $\square$

A second proof: apply Proposition 3.5 to $u = x^{Q_b} - x^{Q_a}$ from both ends. The Rayleigh quotient of u is $\mu_a(1 + (W_b - W_a)/W(\Delta)) = \mu_b(1 + (W_a - W_b)/W(\Delta))$, with $W_a = W(Q_a)$ and $W(\Delta) = W(D_a) + W(D_b)$, which rearranges to the identity.

Corollary 5.2. *Cliques of equal weight anchored in one wrapper share one level; in particular all maximum weight cliques do. Pairwise disjoint anchored cliques have levels proportional to their weights.*

For three or more cliques the pairwise ratios $W(D_a)/W(D_b)$ must also be consistent around every cycle, which for overlapping cliques of different weights generically fails, and then only the level 0 remains.

Theorem 5.3 (collision). *Let H anchor distinct maximal cliques $Q_1, \dots, Q_k$, $k \geq 2$, at a common level $\mu \neq 0$, and let $E = \ker(\mu I - \hat{H}) \cap z^\perp$. Then*

- (a) *every difference $x^{Q_a} - x^{Q_b}$ lies in E , so μ is an eigenvalue of $\hat{H}$ of multiplicity at least $d = \dim \text{aff}\{x^{Q_1}, \dots, x^{Q_k}\} \geq 1$;*

(b) $\hat{b} \perp E$: the linear form c vanishes on the whole eigenspace;

(c) $\hat{x}^{Q_a} = \hat{x}_p + e_a$ with a common $\hat{x}_p \in E^\perp$ and $e_a \in E$; if the $W(Q_a)$ are equal, no x^{Q_a} lies on the secular curve, which passes through $x^0 + \hat{x}_p$ at μ .

Proof. By Lemma 3.3, $(\mu I - \hat{H})\hat{x}^{Q_a} = \hat{b}$ for every a ; subtracting two of these gives (a). Then $\hat{b}$ lies in the range of the symmetric operator $\mu I - \hat{H}$ on $z^\perp$, which is $E^\perp$, giving (b). Decompose $\hat{x}^{Q_a}$ along $E^\perp \oplus E$; the $E^\perp$ components solve the same nonsingular system on $E^\perp$ and so coincide. If the weights are equal, $\|\hat{x}^{Q_a}\|^2 = 1/W(Q_a) - 1/W(V)$ is the same for all a , hence so is $\|e_a\|$; if one e_a vanished all would, and all the indicators would coincide. Since $c = 0$ on E , the secular curve has no pole at μ and tends to $x^0 + (\mu I - \hat{H})^+ \hat{b} = x^0 + \hat{x}_p$ there; at any other multiplier it cannot meet x^{Q_a} , whose multiplier is μ by Lemma 3.3. $\square$

This is precisely the “degenerate case of multiple eigenvalues with $c_i = 0$ ” that [CW, Section 5] sets aside: anchoring several cliques of equal weight forces it, whatever the remaining free entries. The contrapositive is useful as well: if $\hat{b}$ has a nonzero component along $x^{Q_a} - x^{Q_b}$ for two cliques of equal weight, then H does not anchor both. Making a degenerate direction “active” ($c \neq 0$ on it) and anchoring the cliques that span it are mutually exclusive.

Theorem 5.4 (two cliques). *Let $Q_a \neq Q_b$ be maximal cliques and let B be the bipartite graph on $D_a \cup D_b$ whose edges are the non-adjacent pairs of G between D_a and D_b . There is $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$ anchoring Q_a and Q_b at nonzero levels iff*

- (i) every connected component Γ of B satisfies $W(\Gamma \cap D_a)/W(\Gamma \cap D_b) = W(D_a)/W(D_b)$, and
- (ii) if some vertex outside $Q_a \cup Q_b$ is adjacent to all of $Q_a \triangle Q_b$, then $W(Q_a) = W(Q_b)$.

The levels then satisfy $\mu_a : \mu_b = W(D_a) : W(D_b)$.

Proof. Every vertex of B has a neighbour in B : a vertex $j \in D_a$ adjacent to all of D_b would be adjacent to all of Q_b , contradicting maximality. The equations (7) and the defects they involve split into independent blocks.

Outside vertices. For $i \notin Q_a \cup Q_b$ let $A_i = D_a \setminus N(i)$, $B_i = D_b \setminus N(i)$, $K_i = K \setminus N(i)$. The equations of i are $\tau(K_i) + \tau(A_i) = \mu_a$ and $\tau(K_i) + \tau(B_i) = \mu_b$, where $\tau(S) = \sum_{j \in S} w_j \tau_{ij}$, and their defects occur in no other equation. By maximality $K_i \cup A_i$ and $K_i \cup B_i$ are nonempty. If $A_i = B_i = \emptyset$ (i.e. i is adjacent to all of $Q_a \triangle Q_b$), both read $\tau(K_i) = \mu_a = \mu_b$; otherwise they are solvable for any levels (if, say, $B_i = \emptyset \neq A_i$, set $\tau(K_i) = \mu_b$ and $\tau(A_i) = \mu_a - \mu_b$).

The two differences. As in the proof of Theorem 5.1 the remaining equations are, with $\xi_{ij} = w_i w_j \tau_{ij}$ on the edges of B , $\sum_j \xi_{ij} = w_i \mu_a$ for $i \in D_b$ and $\sum_i \xi_{ij} = w_j \mu_b$ for $j \in D_a$: edge values of B with prescribed sums at the vertices. The incidence matrix of a connected bipartite graph has corank one, its left kernel spanned by the vector that is +1 on one side and -1 on the other; so this is solvable iff every component satisfies $\mu_a W(\Gamma \cap D_b) = \mu_b W(\Gamma \cap D_a)$. Summing over components gives Theorem 5.1, and for nonzero levels the component conditions hold iff (i) does. With (ii) for the outside vertices this proves the claim. $\square$

Corollary 5.5. *Any two maximum weight cliques can be anchored in one wrapper at a common positive level with all defects nonnegative.*

Proof. Here $W(D_a) = W(D_b)$ and the level is common. For $S \subseteq D_b$ let $N_B(S)$ be its neighbourhood in B . The set $(Q_a \setminus N_B(S)) \cup S$ is a clique (vertices of S are adjacent to K , and to every vertex of D_a outside $N_B(S)$), of weight $W(Q_a) - W(N_B(S)) + W(S)$, so $W(N_B(S)) \geq W(S)$ by maximality of $W(Q_a)$. By the supply-demand theorem of Gale [Ga57], the transportation problem with supplies $w_i\mu$ on D_b , demands $w_j\mu$ on D_a and routes along the edges of B then has a nonnegative solution. For an outside vertex i take $\tau(K_i) = \mu$ and $\tau(A_i) = \tau(B_i) = 0$ if A_i or B_i is empty (K_i is then nonempty), and $\tau(K_i) = 0$, $\tau(A_i) = \tau(B_i) = \mu$ otherwise, spreading each sum evenly over its non-edges. $\square$

Nonnegative, however, does not mean proper:

Proposition 5.6 (forced blindness). *Let H anchor Q_a and Q_b at a common level, and let $i \notin Q_a \cup Q_b$ be adjacent to all of D_b . Then $\sum_{j \in D_a \setminus N(i)} w_j \tau_{ij} = 0$. In particular a proper wrapper cannot anchor both if such an i has a non-neighbour in D_a ; with nonnegative defects all these τ_{ij} vanish, so $h_{ij} = z_i z_j$ on those non-edges: the wrapper does not distinguish them from edges.*

Proof. Subtract the two equations of i in the proof of Theorem 5.4: with $B_i = \emptyset$ they give $\tau(A_i) = \mu_a - \mu_b = 0$. $\square$

In dense graphs, maximum cliques that differ by a single exchange $Q_b = Q_a - j + j'$ are common, and every outside vertex i adjacent to j' but not to j then makes the non-edge $\{i, j\}$ invisible, here without any sign condition, since $D_a = \{j\}$ leaves a single defect in the sum. Once invisible non-edges cover all the non-neighbours of some vertex in some other anchored clique, that vertex's equation reads $0 = \mu$ and the common level collapses; Example 6.9 shows this with three maximum cliques.

6 Anchoring every maximum clique

6.1 The best relaxation is the Lovász number

Theorem 6.1. *For every $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$, $v(H) \leq 1/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$, with equality whenever $\lambda_{\max}(H) = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$. Hence*

$$\max_{H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)} \min\{x^T x : x \in \mathcal{W}^H\} = \frac{1}{\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)}.$$

Proof. Equality for Lovász-optimal H . For $x \in \mathcal{W}^H$, $1 = x^T H x \leq \lambda_{\max}(H) x^T x = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w) x^T x$, so $v(H) \geq 1/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$; the upper bound below then gives equality.

The upper bound. Consider the semidefinite relaxation

$$v_{\text{SDP}}(H) = \min\{\text{tr } X : \langle H, X \rangle = 1, \langle zz^T, X \rangle = 1, X \succeq 0\}.$$

If $x \in \mathcal{W}^H$ then $X = xx^T$ is feasible with $\text{tr } X = x^T x$, so $v_{\text{SDP}}(H) \leq v(H)$. Conversely, the feasible set is nonempty and the trace is bounded below and coercive on it, so the minimum is attained and the optimal set is a nonempty compact face of the feasible set. An extreme point of it is an extreme point of the feasible set, which is cut out of the positive semidefinite cone by two linear equations; by the rank bound of Barvinok and Pataki [Ba95, Pa98] it has rank r with $r(r+1)/2 \leq 2$, so $r \leq 1$, and $r = 0$ is excluded by $\langle zz^T, X \rangle = 1$. Writing it as xx^T with $z^T x = 1$ (replacing x by $-x$ if necessary) gives $x \in \mathcal{W}^H$ with $x^T x = v_{\text{SDP}}(H)$. Hence $v(H) = v_{\text{SDP}}(H)$.

Now let X^* be a Lovász optimum. H and zz^T agree on the support of X^* (the diagonal and E), so $X = X^*/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ has $\langle H, X \rangle = \langle zz^T, X \rangle = 1$ and $\text{tr } X = 1/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$. Thus $v(H) = v_{\text{SDP}}(H) \leq 1/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$. $\square$

So every wrapping matrix gives an upper bound $1/v(H) \geq \vartheta(\bar{G}, w) \geq \omega(G, w)$ on the weighted clique number, and the Lovász-optimal wrappers give the best of them. In the sense of the relaxed least squares program they are the best wrappers. By Lemma 2.5, v is constant on gauge orbits. For the standard wrapper of a regular graph the bound is a classical one:

Corollary 6.2. *Let G be d -regular, not complete, with unit weights, and let λ_2 be the largest eigenvalue of A_G on $\mathbf{1}^\perp$. Then*

$$\frac{1}{v(H_0)} = \frac{n(1 + \lambda_2)}{n - d + \lambda_2},$$

Hoffman's ratio bound [Ho70] on $\alpha(\bar{G}) = \omega(G)$ applied to the $(n - 1 - d)$ -regular graph $\bar{G}$.

Proof. Here $x^0 = \mathbf{1}/n$ and $H_0 x^0 = (1 + d)x^0$, so $\hat{b} = 0$ and $s = 1 - (1 + d)/n$. As A_G preserves $\mathbf{1}^\perp$, $\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H}_0) = 1 + \lambda_2$, which is at least 1 for a non-complete graph (λ_2 is then the second eigenvalue of A_G , at least 0 by interlacing with two non-adjacent vertices). The program is $\min \|\hat{x}\|^2$ subject to $\hat{x}^T \hat{H}_0 \hat{x} = s$, with value $s/(1 + \lambda_2)$, so $v(H_0) = 1/n + (n - 1 - d)/(n(1 + \lambda_2))$, which rearranges to the claim. The smallest eigenvalue of $A_{\bar{G}}$ is $-1 - \lambda_2$, and Hoffman's bound for $\bar{G}$ is $n(1 + \lambda_2)/(n - 1 - d + 1 + \lambda_2)$. $\square$

With Theorem 6.1 this recovers Lovász's inequality $\vartheta \leq$ Hoffman's bound for regular graphs [Lo79, Theorem 9]: passing from the standard to a Lovász-optimal wrapper improves the relaxed bound from Hoffman's to ϑ .

6.2 Global anchoring

Theorem 6.3. *For a clique Q the following are equivalent:*

- (a) x^Q is a global minimizer of (5) for some $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$;
- (b) $W(Q) = \omega(G, w) = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$.

If they hold, every Lovász-optimal H anchors every maximum weight clique at level $\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ ($C = 0$), and every maximum weight clique indicator is a global minimizer of (5) for it. Moreover, if some H anchors a clique Q at a level $\mu > 0$ with $\mu \geq \lambda_{\max}(\hat{H})$, then (b) holds.

Proof. (a) $\Rightarrow$ (b): $1/W(Q) = \|x^Q\|^2 = v(H) \leq 1/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ by Theorem 6.1, so $W(Q) \geq \vartheta(\bar{G}, w) \geq \omega(G, w) \geq W(Q)$. (b) $\Rightarrow$ (a): for Lovász-optimal H , $v(H) = 1/\vartheta(\bar{G}, w) = 1/W(Q) = \|x^Q\|^2$. For a Lovász-optimal H and a maximum weight clique Q' , the Rayleigh quotient of $z_{Q'}$ is $W(Q') = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w) = \lambda_{\max}(H)$ (Lemma 2.2), so $z_{Q'}$ is a top eigenvector, $H z_{Q'} = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w) z_{Q'}$, which is Lemma 3.2(c) with $\mu = W(Q') = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$. The last claim follows from Lemmas 3.3 and 2.3(a) and (a) $\Rightarrow$ (b). $\square$

So the relaxed program can be exact, in the sense that some wrapper makes a clique indicator its global minimizer, exactly when $\vartheta = \omega$; and then *anchoring one maximum clique globally is the same as anchoring all of them*. On graphs with $\vartheta > \omega$, which include most hard benchmark graphs, every anchored clique is a non-global stationary point. This is why QUALEX-MS must examine the stationary points in all intervals of the secular equation and not only the one beyond $\lambda_{\max}$.

Corollary 6.4 (the hard case). *Let $\vartheta(\bar{G}, w) = \omega(G, w)$ and let G have $k \geq 2$ maximum weight cliques, whose indicators span an affine space of dimension d . For every Lovász-optimal H , $\mu = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ equals $\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H})$, with multiplicity at least d and with $\hat{b}$ orthogonal to its eigenspace. The multiplicity of $\lambda_{\max}(H)$ is at least the rank of every Lovász optimum, in particular at least $\dim \text{span}\{z_Q\}$ over the maximum weight cliques Q .*

Proof. All maximum cliques are anchored at $\mu = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ (Theorem 6.3). The restriction of $\hat{H}$ to $z^\perp$ is a compression of H , so $\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H}) \leq \lambda_{\max}(H) = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ by interlacing, while Theorem 5.3 makes μ an eigenvalue of $\hat{H}$ of multiplicity at least d with $\hat{b}$ orthogonal to its eigenspace. By (4) the range of every Lovász optimum X lies in $\ker(\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)I - H)$, and the matrices X_Q of Lemma 2.2 are Lovász optima when $W(Q) = \vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$. $\square$

In trust region terms, the sphere of radius $\|\hat{x}^Q\|$ is in the *hard case* [MS83]: its global maximizers form a sphere inside $x^0 + \hat{x}_p + E$, which contains all the maximum clique indicators, none of them on the secular curve. This is the structural reason why the Lovász-optimal wrappers, although best by Theorem 6.1, are useless for recognizing a clique through the secular equation when there are several maximum cliques. When $\vartheta > \omega$ the Lovász-optimal wrappers are degenerate for a different reason, the generic multiplicity of optimal eigenvalues [Ov92, Pa98]; Section 7 shows both.

6.3 Colourings, holes and perfect graphs

In this subsection all weights are 1, so $z = \mathbf{1}$ and $\hat{H}, \tau$ are those of an unweighted graph.

Proposition 6.5 (the colouring wrapper). *Let $\chi(G) = \omega(G) = \omega$, with colour classes $S_1, \dots, S_\omega$. Then*

$$H_\chi = \omega I - \left(\omega \sum_{c=1}^{\omega} \mathbf{1}_{S_c} \mathbf{1}_{S_c}^T - \mathbf{1} \mathbf{1}^T \right)$$

lies in $\mathcal{H}(G, \mathbf{1})$, with defects $\tau_{ij} = \omega$ inside colour classes and $\tau_{ij} = 0$ between them, has $\lambda_{\max}(H_\chi) = \omega$ and anchors every maximum clique at level ω ($C = 0$).

Proof. The diagonal of H_χ is $\omega - (\omega - 1) = 1$; between classes the entries are 1, which covers all edges; inside a class (non-adjacent pairs) they are $1 - \omega$. The bracket is positive semidefinite by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality, $\omega \sum_c (\mathbf{1}_{S_c}^T x)^2 \geq (\sum_c \mathbf{1}_{S_c}^T x)^2$, so $H_\chi \preceq \omega I$, and $\lambda_{\max}(H_\chi) = \omega$ by Lemma 2.2. A maximum clique Q meets every class in one vertex; for $i \notin Q$ in class c , $\sum_{j \in Q} h_{ij} = (1 - \omega) + (\omega - 1) = 0$, so $C = 0$. $\square$

The colouring wrapper sees only the complete ω -partite graph on the colour classes: the indicator of every transversal of the colouring lies on $\mathcal{W}^{H_\chi}$ and has norm $1/\sqrt{\omega}$, exactly like a maximum clique, although most transversals are not cliques. Such pseudo-cliques are what the strict inequality of [CW, Proposition 2] rules out; the colouring wrapper is improper as soon as two colour classes are not completely joined.

Theorem 6.6. *Let G be an odd hole C_{2k+1} or an odd antihole $\bar{C}_{2k+1}$, $k \geq 2$, with unit weights. Every $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, \mathbf{1})$ that anchors all maximum cliques of G does so at level 0, and then $H = \mathbf{1} \mathbf{1}^T$.*

Proof. All maximum cliques share one level μ (Corollary 5.2). Vertices are taken modulo $n = 2k + 1$.

Odd holes. The maximum cliques are the edges $\{a, a+1\}$. For $Q = \{a, a+1\}$ the outside vertex $a+2$ misses only a and $a-1$ misses only $a+1$, so every non-edge at distance 2 has $\tau = \mu$; a vertex v with $a+3 \leq v \leq a-2$ misses both, giving $\tau_{a,v} + \tau_{a+1,v} = \mu$. With $v = a+j+1$ this reads $\tau_{a,a+j+1} = \mu - \tau_{a+1,a+j+1}$, so by induction on j every pair $\{b, b+j\}$ has $\tau = \mu$ for even j and $\tau = 0$ for odd j , $2 \leq j \leq n-2$. The pair $\{b, b+2\}$ is also the pair $\{b+2, (b+2) + (n-2)\}$ with $n-2$ odd, so $\mu = 0$, and then every defect is 0.

Odd antiholes. The non-edges are the pairs $\{b, b+1\}$; write τ_b for their defects. The maximum cliques of $\bar{C}_{2k+1}$ are the stable sets of size k of C_{2k+1} , namely $Q_a = \{a, a+2, \dots, a+2k-2\}$ (consecutive elements differ by 2 except for one gap of 3). The non-neighbours of an outside vertex v in Q_a are its neighbours on the cycle that belong to Q_a . For $v = a+2k-1$ this is $\{a+2k-2\}$ and for $v = a+2k$ it is $\{a\}$, so $\tau_{a+2k-2} = \mu$ and $\tau_{a-1} = \mu$ for all a : every defect equals μ . For $v = a+1$ (which is outside Q_a since $k \geq 2$) it is $\{a, a+2\}$, giving $\tau_a + \tau_{a+1} = \mu$, i.e. $2\mu = \mu$. So $\mu = 0$ and all defects vanish. $\square$

Even holes behave differently. The same induction shows that H anchors all maximum cliques of C_{2k} ($k \geq 2$) iff $\tau = \mu$ at even distances and $\tau = 0$ at odd distances, which is consistent because j and $2k-j$ have the same parity. At $\mu = 2$ this is the colouring wrapper of the bipartition, so it is Lovász-optimal ($\vartheta = \omega = 2$). For $k \geq 3$ the odd-distance non-edges are invisible to *every* wrapper anchoring all maximum cliques, hence to every Lovász-optimal wrapper. For C_6 the three long diagonals $\{i, i+3\}$ then satisfy $x^T H x = 1$ for $x = (e_i + e_{i+3})/2 \in \Delta_n$, which has $x^T x = 1/2 = 1/\omega$: they are global minimizers of the program of [CW, Theorem 1] although they are not cliques. The Lovász-optimal wrappers of C_6 are necessarily improper.

Theorem 6.7. *For a graph G with unit weights the following are equivalent:*

- (a) G is perfect;
- (b) for every induced subgraph G' of G some $H \in \mathcal{H}(G', 1)$ anchors all maximum cliques of G' at a common nonzero level.

When (a) holds, H in (b) can be taken Lovász-optimal for G' .

Proof. (a) $\Rightarrow$ (b): induced subgraphs of perfect graphs are perfect, so $\chi(G') = \omega(G')$, and Proposition 6.5 applies. (b) $\Rightarrow$ (a): if G is not perfect, by the strong perfect graph theorem [CRST06] it has an induced odd hole or odd antihole, for which (b) fails by Theorem 6.6. $\square$

Condition (b) is linear (no semidefiniteness is involved), but it must be required hereditarily: an imperfect graph with a unique maximum clique satisfies it for $G' = G$, and so do the graphs of Section 7 with $\vartheta > \omega$ whose maximum cliques can all be anchored. One direction holds without heredity:

Corollary 6.8. *If the maximum weight cliques of G cannot all be anchored at a common nonzero level, then $\vartheta(\bar{G}, w) > \omega(G, w)$.*

Proof. If $\vartheta(\bar{G}, w) = \omega(G, w)$, a Lovász-optimal wrapper anchors them all at level $\vartheta(\bar{G}, w)$ (Theorem 6.3). $\square$

Example 6.9. The unweighted random graph g200_80_0 ($n = 200$, $p = 0.8$, $\omega = 26$) has three maximum cliques. $Q_2 = Q_1 - 14 + 53$ (vertex labels of the DIMACS file), and Q_3 shares only four vertices with them. The vertices 95, 113, 158 and 176 of Q_3 are adjacent to 53 but not

to 14, so by Proposition 5.6 (with $D_a = \{14\}$, a single vertex, so without any sign condition) $\tau_{i,14} = 0$ for each of them. But these four are exactly the non-neighbours of vertex 14 in Q_3 , so the equation of 14 for Q_3 reads $0 = \mu$. The system has 418 distinct equations in 1693 defects and is still inconsistent; this certificate combines nine of them.

7 Computations

7.1 Tools

The maximum cliques were listed with an unpublished maximal clique enumerator (CLEN). The system (7) with a common level was set up with repeated equations removed and tested for a solution at level 1 (least squares, confirmed by linear programming); when solvable, the spectrum was examined for the solution nearest the standard wrapper (least change of the defects, level free), and nonnegative solutions were explored by linear programming (largest smallest defect, and the defects that vanish in every nonnegative solution). ϑ was computed with CSDP [Bo99] from whichever of two equivalent programs has fewer constraints: (3), one constraint per non-edge, or $\min t$ subject to $tI - H \succeq 0$, $H \in \mathcal{H}(G, w)$, i.e. a positive semidefinite $Y = tI - H$ with $y_{ii} = t - 1$ and $y_{ij} = -1$ on E , one constraint per edge. The Lovász-optimal H was recovered from the solution. The scripts are `bench/anchor_all.py` and `bench/theta.py` of the QUALEX-MS repository (commit c9af3f8), and their outputs are `bench/runs/anchor-all-2026-09-26.txt` and `bench/runs/theta/theta.tsv`.

The following checks agree with the statements above: Theorem 5.1 to $4 \cdot 10^{-13}$ on 127 pairs of maximal cliques of weighted $G(40, 0.5)$ that admit nonzero levels; the criterion of Theorem 5.4 on all 150 pairs tried (23 of which admit only level 0); Proposition 3.5 to 10^{-15} on 1997 pairs of cliques; Theorem 5.3 with multiplicity equal to d and $|c| \leq 10^{-16}$ on the eigenspace; Theorem 6.6 and the even hole statement for $C_5, \dots, C_{10}$ and $\bar{C}_7, \bar{C}_9, \bar{C}_{11}$; for C_5 , over a grid of the free parameters of one anchored edge, $\lambda_{\max}(\hat{H}) - \mu \geq 0.138$ (Theorem 6.3, $\vartheta = \sqrt{5} > 2$); the colouring wrapper on random interval graphs; and Theorem 6.1 and Corollary 6.2 on the graphs of Table 5. CSDP was validated on `hamming6-2` (32), `johnson8-4-4` (14), `hamming6-4` (16/3) and `MANN_a9` (17.47503), with both programs and with CSDP's own `theta` program.

7.2 Anchoring all maximum cliques of DIMACS graphs

Table 3 covers every DIMACS graph with $n \leq 1100$ and between 2 and 20000 maximum cliques. For 11 of them the common level is forced to 0; by Corollary 6.8 all have $\vartheta > \omega$. For the other 20 the level is free. On 6 of these the anchoring nearest the standard wrapper already puts μ at the top of the spectrum of $\hat{H}$, which by Theorem 6.3 certifies $\vartheta = \omega$; for five of them the standard wrapper itself anchors all maximum cliques, because every outside vertex has the same number of non-neighbours in each. (For `johnson8-4-4` the maximum cliques are the 30 Steiner systems $S(3, 4, 8)$, and a 4-set outside such a system meets exactly 4 of its 14 blocks in three points.) On the remaining 14 the nearest anchoring leaves between 2 and 232 eigenvalues above μ , and CSDP decides: $\vartheta = \omega$ on 8 of them and $\vartheta > \omega$ on 6. Wherever the level is free, the multiplicity of μ in $\hat{H}$ equals d exactly, as Theorem 5.3 predicts as a lower bound, with the single exception of `hamming8-4` (127 against 71).

Two features of the solutions are worth recording. First, Proposition 5.6 is not an exception. Only 7 of the 20 graphs, the six symmetric ones and `brock200_1`, admit a proper anchoring of all

graph	n	ω	k	d	common level	above μ	$\vartheta(G)$
p_hat300-1	300	8	13	12	forced to 0		$> \omega$
sanr200_0.7	200	18	13	10	forced to 0		$> \omega$
p_hat300-2	300	25	52	17	forced to 0		$> \omega$
DSJC500.5	500	13	56	55	forced to 0		$> \omega$
p_hat500-1	500	9	78	74	forced to 0		$> \omega$
p_hat700-2	700	44	138	23	forced to 0		$> \omega$
hamming6-4	64	4	240	51	forced to 0		5.33333
p_hat1000-1	1000	10	276	260	forced to 0		$> \omega$
C125.9	125	34	924	24	forced to 0		$> \omega$
keller4	171	11	2304	133	forced to 0		$> \omega$
MANN_a9	45	16	9540	44	forced to 0		17.47503
hamming6-2	64	32	2	1	free, standard	0	32
hamming8-2	256	128	2	1	free, standard	0	$= \omega$
hamming10-2	1024	512	2	1	free, standard	0	$= \omega$
johnson8-4-4	70	14	30	14	free, standard	0	14
johnson8-2-4	28	4	105	20	free, standard	0	$= \omega$
hamming8-4	256	16	480	71	free	0	$= \omega$
san200_0.7_2	200	18	2	1	free	43	18
gen200_p0.9_55	200	55	4	2	free	13	55
gen200_p0.9_44	200	44	4	2	free	33	44
c-fat200-1	200	12	14	13	free	8	12
c-fat500-1	500	14	19	18	free	19	14
c-fat500-2	500	26	19	18	free	7	26
c-fat500-5	500	64	3	2	free	4	64
c-fat500-10	500	126	3	2	free	2	126
brock200_1	200	21	2	1	free	49	27.45664
p_hat700-1	700	11	2	1	free	232	15.11986
c-fat200-5	200	58	3	2	free	2	60.34528
sanr400_0.5	400	13	4	3	free	143	20.31766
p_hat300-3	300	36	10	5	free	90	41.16993
p_hat500-2	500	36	14	5	free	151	38.97466

Table 3: DIMACS graphs with $2 \leq k \leq 20000$ maximum cliques and $n \leq 1100$. d is the dimension of the affine hull of their indicators; “standard”: the standard wrapper already anchors them all; “above μ ”: eigenvalues of $\hat{H}$ above the common level for the anchoring nearest the standard wrapper. ϑ : computed with CSDP where a value is given; $> \omega$ by Corollary 6.8; $= \omega$ by Theorem 6.3 (and, for the hamming graphs of distance 2, which are complements of bipartite graphs, by perfection).

their maximum cliques; on the other 13, between 2.6% (`san200_0.7_2`) and 23% (`c-fat200-5`) of the non-edges involved are invisible in every nonnegative solution. (The solutions (τ, μ) form a cone, so a single linear program finds these non-edges: maximize $\sum_k \min(\tau_k, 1)$ subject to (7), $\tau \geq 0$ and $\mu \geq 1$; exactly the defects that can be positive reach 1.) Second, in the graphs with the level forced to 0 the collapse is local and has small certificates, of the kind of Example 6.9.

7.3 Random graphs

On the 35 unweighted random graphs with proven ω ($n = 200$ with $p \leq 0.8$ and $n = 300$ with $p \leq 0.7$), 5 have a unique maximum clique. Of the 30 others the common level is forced to 0 on 17 (with k between 3 and 797) and free on 13 (with k between 2 and 15); where free, μ had 55 to 99 eigenvalues of $\hat{H}$ above it and the multiplicity of μ was d exactly. One of the 13 admitted no nonnegative solution, 5 admitted proper ones, and on the other 7 between 2.1% and 9.4% of the non-edges involved are invisible in every nonnegative solution. Weighted random graphs almost always have a unique maximum weight clique, for which anchoring is the single clique construction of Section 3.

7.4 The Lovász number of the 14 undecided graphs

Table 4 lists the CSDP results for the 14 graphs on which the nearest anchoring stayed below the top. In all eight graphs with $\vartheta = \omega$ the optimal wrapper anchors every maximum clique at $C = 0$ (to 10^{-9} to 10^{-4}), as Theorem 6.3 requires. The multiplicity of $\lambda_{\max}(H)$ agrees with the rank of the Lovász optimum found by CSDP (strict complementarity) and, but for one graph, with $\dim \text{span}\{z_Q\}$, the lower bound of Corollary 6.4. The exception is `gen200_p0.9_44`: its Lovász optimum has rank 157 and a positive diagonal on all 200 vertices, so by (4) every Lovász-optimal wrapper has a top eigenvalue of multiplicity at least 157, though its four maximum cliques span only 3 dimensions. The optimal face of (3) contains “vector cliques” that are not cliques. When $\vartheta > \omega$ the top multiplicities are large and unrelated to the cliques; on the largest graphs the top of the spectrum decays gradually and the multiplicity is only defined up to the solver’s accuracy.

7.5 Relaxed bounds of the standard and the optimal wrapper

Table 5 compares the bound $1/v(H)$ of Theorem 6.1 for the standard wrapper and for the optimal wrapper found by CSDP; $v(H)$ was computed from the secular equation as the stationary point with the largest multiplier (Lemma 2.3), including the hard case. For the optimal wrappers $1/v(H) = \vartheta$ to the accuracy of the solver (relative error below $3 \cdot 10^{-6}$); on the three regular graphs $1/v(H_0)$ equals Hoffman’s bound, as Corollary 6.2 states; elsewhere the standard wrapper’s bound can be very weak (`san200_0.7_2`: 115.8 against $\vartheta = 18$).

8 Conclusions and open questions

For one clique, anchoring is always possible and puts the clique on the secular curve; its effect is local, with ascent towards heavier cliques in proportion to the gain per exchanged weight. Used on the solver’s own best clique it is a reliable improvement step, used on a poor clique it is harmful. For several cliques, the free entries are far fewer in effect than in number: the levels are forced by the level identity, cliques of equal weight collide into the degenerate case, and

graph	ω	$\vartheta(G)$	$\dim \text{span}\{z_Q\}$	rank of X^*	mult. of $\lambda_{\max}(H)$
c-fat200-1	12	12.000000	14	14	14
c-fat500-1	14	14.000000	19	19	19
c-fat500-2	26	26.000000	19	19	19
c-fat500-5	64	64.000001	3	3	3
c-fat500-10	126	126.000000	3	3	3
gen200_p0.9_55	55	55.000000	3	3	3
gen200_p0.9_44	44	44.000000	3	157	157
san200_0.7_2	18	18.000000	2	2	2
brock200_1	21	27.456641	2	63	63
c-fat200-5	58	60.345275	3	5	5
p_hat300-3	36	41.169930	6	101	101
sanr400_0.5	13	20.317656	4	≈ 200	≈ 200
p_hat500-2	36	38.974658	6	~ 150	~ 150
p_hat700-1	11	15.119858	2	~ 450	~ 450

Table 4: The Lovász number of the complement (CSDP, relative duality gaps below 10^{-8}), the dimension spanned by the maximum cliques, the rank of the Lovász optimum X^* and the multiplicity of the top eigenvalue of the optimal wrapper, both read at the largest relative gap in the spectrum. For **sanr400_0.5** that gap lies between 199 and 201. For the last two graphs there is no clear gap: counting eigenvalues within relative distances 10^{-6} to 10^{-4} gives 74 to 165 (**p_hat500-2**) and 428 to 486 (**p_hat700-1**). The largest problems had 61800 constraints and took 42 and 47 minutes.

the remaining system may force non-edges to be invisible or the level to vanish. Anchoring all maximum cliques at the top of the spectrum is possible exactly when $\vartheta = \omega$, and then it is what every Lovász-optimal wrapper does; this explains the degeneracy of the Lovász-optimal wrappers observed in QUALEX-MS, even though by Theorem 6.1 they are the best wrappers for the relaxed program. On odd holes and odd antiholes no nontrivial wrapper anchors all maximum cliques, and this characterizes perfect graphs through the strong perfect graph theorem.

Questions left open:

1. Characterize the graphs whose maximum cliques can all be anchored at a nonzero level; the condition is not hereditary, and Theorem 5.4 settles only pairs.
2. Given that $\vartheta > \omega$, how few eigenvalues can lie above the common level of an anchoring? This is an eigenvalue optimization over the affine family of anchoring wrappers.
3. Is there a weighted analogue of Theorem 6.7, i.e. which weighted graphs have, hereditarily, anchorings of all maximum weight cliques?
4. What structure makes the Lovász optimum of **gen200_p0.9_44** full support and rank 157, and is it typical of generated instances with a planted clique?
5. Can the hard case be used rather than avoided? When QUALEX-MS finds a cluster with $c = 0$, cliques anchored together sit on a sphere in $x^0 + \hat{x}_p + E$; with $\dim E = 1$ (**hamming6-2**) the eigenvector itself leads to them, but for larger E a search inside E (for instance over the vertices of $\{x \geq 0\} \cap (x^0 + \hat{x}_p + E)$) would be needed.

graph	ω	$\vartheta(G)$	$1/v(H_0)$	Hoffman
hamming6-2	32	32.000	32.000	32.000
johnson8-4-4	14	14.000	14.000	14.000
hamming6-4	4	5.333	13.538	13.538
MANN_a9	16	17.475	19.707	
c-fat200-1	12	12.000	17.430	
gen200_p0.9_55	55	55.000	75.624	
gen200_p0.9_44	44	44.000	72.547	
san200_0.7_2	18	18.000	115.759	
brock200_1	21	27.457	43.287	
c-fat200-5	58	60.345	72.905	
p_hat300-3	36	41.170	88.374	

Table 5: The relaxed bound $1/v(H)$ for the standard wrapper against ϑ , which the optimal wrapper attains (Theorem 6.1), and Hoffman’s bound for the regular graphs.

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